

Brand defense

Search architecture for tightly controlled branded demand

PORTFOLIO EXERCISE - NOT CLIENT WORK

QUESTION

How should branded purchase intent be protected without mixing it with broader discovery traffic?

DECISION

Use exact and phrase match, separate exclusions, a CPC guardrail, and trust-led ad assets.

EVIDENCE RETAINED

Strategy rationale, keyword structure, campaign controls, and product-specific sitelinks.

VALIDATION

Check query routing, landing-page alignment, conversion tracking, and impression-share loss before scaling.

SECTION 1

The Strategy: Why These Decisions

Every setting in this build was a deliberate trade-off between visibility, cost control, and account safety. The four decisions below carried the most weight.

1. Exact & Phrase Match Only: No Broad Match

Brand protection campaigns exist to capture a narrow, high-intent set of queries, not to discover new traffic. Keywords were built exclusively as exact match ([apple store], [apple.com], [apple website]) and tightly-scoped phrase match ("buy macbook online", "buy iphone online"). Broad match was deliberately excluded: on a brand campaign it invites impression share on irrelevant, unrelated, or even competitor-adjacent queries, which dilutes Quality Score signals and burns budget the campaign can't afford to lose. Exact and phrase match keep 100% of spend tied to unambiguous brand intent.

2. Pinning “Official Apple® Store” to Headline Position 1

In a responsive search ad, Google's algorithm is free to reorder headlines for predicted performance, which is normally desirable, but not on a defense campaign. The single job of this ad is to signal authenticity and out-rank resellers, marketplaces, and copycat advertisers on the SERP. Pinning “Official Apple® Store” to Position 1 removes that variability: the trust signal is guaranteed to render on every impression, not just the ones the algorithm happens to favor.

3. Maximize Clicks With a Hard €1.50 Max CPC Cap

Maximize Clicks alone is a blank check: Google will spend up to the daily budget chasing volume with no ceiling on individual click cost. Layering a €1.50 max CPC limit on top keeps the automation directionally useful (still optimized for click volume) while capping the worst-case cost per click. On branded terms, where Quality Score is naturally high and true CPCs are typically pennies rather than euros, €1.50 is a conservative backstop, not a real-world spend expectation, which the results in Section 3 confirm.

4. Ignoring Google's Default Budget Recommendations

Google's built-in recommendations engine consistently pushes toward higher daily budgets on branded campaigns, on the logic that more spend captures more impression share. For a defense campaign, that logic is backwards: the traffic is finite (it's your own brand's search volume), and the ad is likely to win the auction cheaply due to strong relevance. Setting a disciplined €10.00/day budget, against the platform's own suggestion, is the difference between an account run for the advertiser's interest and one run for the platform's. The Section 4 metrics show this restraint cost nothing in coverage.

SECTION 2

Step-by-Step Implementation

The build followed a four-stage sequence: keyword architecture, ad creation and extensions, bidding and budget control, and final quality validation. Console screenshots are included where they show a genuine strategic decision rather than a routine platform click.

STAGE 1 · KEYWORD ARCHITECTURE

Brand and product-purchase intent terms were structured into exact and phrase match groups, isolating high-value, unambiguous branded queries from any broader, less qualified search traffic.

Search

Add business information

Create your campaign

Choose goal

Choose campaign

Select keywords

Create ads

Set bid strategy

Set budget

Enter payment details

Define who should see your ads

Keywords

Get keyword suggestions (optional)
Google Ads can find keywords for you by scanning a web page or seeing what's working for similar products or services

Final URL
https://www.apple.com

Add products or services to advertise
Consumer Electronics X Smartphones X Laptops X

[Update keyword suggestions](#)

Enter keywords
Keywords are words or phrases that are used to match your ads with the terms people are searching for

Enter or paste keywords, one word or phrase per line*

"apple official website"
"apple store online"
"buy apple products"
"apple store official"
[apple store]
[apple website]
[apple.com]
"buy iphone online"
"buy macbook online"

Required

Add more keywords: Show your ads more often to people searching for what your business offers +4.4% View Apply all

More settings

Locations
United States

Languages
English

Audiences
Mobile Enthusiasts + 3 more

Networks
Search partners

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Fig. 1: Keyword list showing exact-match brand terms ([apple store], [apple.com], [apple website]) and phrase-match purchase-intent terms ("buy macbook online", "buy iphone online"), all enabled and scoped to the Brand Protection ad group.

Negative Keyword Layer (Applied Off-Screen)

Alongside the positive keyword list, a negative keyword layer was built at the campaign level to further insulate spend.

Job & career intent: "apple careers", "apple jobs", and "apple internship" were filtered out to prevent brand impressions being wasted on recruitment searches. Repair & support intent: "apple repair", "apple support number", and "genius bar appointment" were routed away from a sales-focused ad group. Price-sensitive /

Fig. 2: Core campaign settings page confirming targeted languages (English), rich audience segments (Mobile Enthusiasts +3), and the exclusion of the Google Display Network to avoid wasting budget on non-search inventory.

Create an ad to boost electronics sales for Apple

Final URL
 Final URL
 https://www.apple.com
 This will be used to suggest assets for your ad

Headlines 12/15

Headline	Length
Official Apple® Store	21 / 30
Buy Direct From Apple	21 / 30
Apple Official Site	19 / 30
Shop the Latest iPhone	22 / 30
Powerful New MacBooks	21 / 30
Explore iPad & Apple Watch	26 / 30
Fast, Free Two-Day Shipping	27 / 30
Trade In & Save Big	19 / 30
Flexible Financing Options	26 / 30
Customize with Free Engraving	29 / 30
Certified Refurbished Deals	27 / 30
Shop Apple Accessories	22 / 30

Descriptions 4/4

Description	Length
Shop the official Apple Store online. Enjoy fast, free shipping and easy return policies	88 / 90
Get the best value directly from Apple. Trade in your eligible device for instant credit.	89 / 90
Discover innovative Apple products including iPhone, MacBook, iPad, and Apple Watch.	84 / 90
Explore flexible financing options, trade-in deals, and expert setup support online.	84 / 90

Ad strength: Average

- ☒ Add headlines
- ☒ Include popular keywords
- ☐ Make headlines unique
- ☒ Make descriptions unique
- ☒ Add more sitelinks

Preview

Previews shown here are examples and don't include all possible formats. You're responsible for the content of your ads. Please make sure that your provided assets don't violate any Google policies or applicable laws, either individually, or in combination.

Campaign optimization score
 88.7%

Next

Fig. 3: Responsive search ad build showing the primary headline “Official Apple® Store” pinned to Position 1, guaranteeing the high-trust official brand signal renders on every single impression.

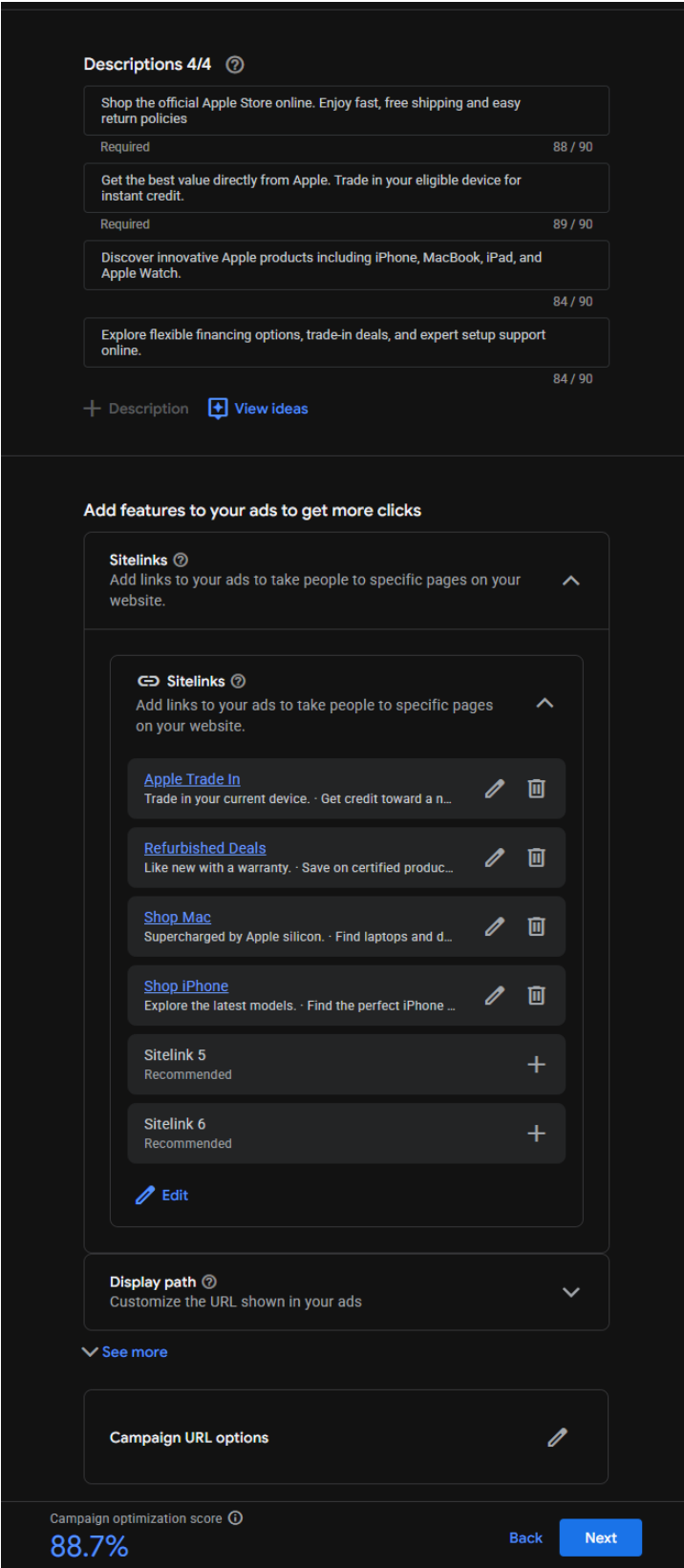


Fig. 4: Configured sitelink assets showing the finalized structural preview for four highly targeted, product-specific extensions ready to expand the ad's visual footprint.